

Preventing HIV/AIDS

Acquired Immuno deficiency Syndrome is caused by Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV). The disease is transmitted by sexual contact with infected partner; transfusion of HIV infected blood, transmission from HIV positive mother to her un-born baby during pregnancy, delivery & through breast feeding, and sharing intravenous needles by drug addicts.

As per global estimates (UN-2006) approximately 39.5 million people in the world may be affected by HIV infection including 2.5 million people living with HIV/AIDS in India. The prevalence of HIV positivity is 0.3% in Delhi.

Once the HIV enters into the body of a person, no symptoms may appear for 8-10 years. The HIV causes impairment of defence mechanisms gradually by attacking CD4 +T-lymphocytes, a blood corpuscle associated with body defence. As a result, even trivial infections become serious in such individuals. Without adequate management most of the HIV positive individuals die in due course. Though, antiretroviral therapy(ART) has become available in India in 2004, the treatment is costly and adherence to treatment is a big problem. However, if properly adhered to, the results of the treatment are promising.

With simple precautions, HIV infection can be easily prevented. Some of these include following:

- Safe Sex Practices, Avoid sex with multiple partners, Use condoms to protect against sexually transmitted infections & HIV
- Safe Blood transfusion: Blood is tested for HIV status before transfusion. It should be obtained only from licensed blood banks.
- Use of disposable intravenous needles for injections.
- Screening all pregnant mothers for HIV infection –to prevent transmission of infection from infected mother to her baby.
- Observing Universal Precautions for handling blood products and body secretions

State AIDS Control Programme:
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